GERRIT COLE VS. BOSTON RED SOX

2026 Pitching Analysis & Matchup Scouting Report

Prepared by Corey Bannerman | R, dplyr, ggplot2 | Statcast

Executive summary

This project examines Gerrit Cole's 2026 pitch characteristics, swing-and-miss results, pitch selection, location patterns, and potential matchup considerations against Boston hitters. It combines pitcher and hitter whiff rates by pitch type to prioritize situations for closer scouting review.

Profile at a glance

- Four-seam fastball: 49.1% usage and 96.8 mph average velocity.
- Slider: 20.0% usage and 26.3% overall whiff rate.
- Knuckle curve: 14.1% usage; changeup: 12.9% usage.
- Top exploratory matchup: Carlos Narvaez vs. slider (36.7% score).

Key findings

- Cole relies primarily on his four-seam fastball, with the slider providing the highest overall whiff rate in this dataset.
- Pitch location and count influence how his arsenal is deployed; the visualizations show usage and observed outcomes, not causal effects.
- Boston hitters display meaningful differences in whiff rate across changeups, fastballs, and sliders.

Scouting interpretation

The matchup heatmap is a screening tool. Its score averages Cole's pitch-type whiff rate with each hitter's whiff rate against that pitch type. It is not a projection of a future at-bat, strikeout probability, or expected whiff rate.

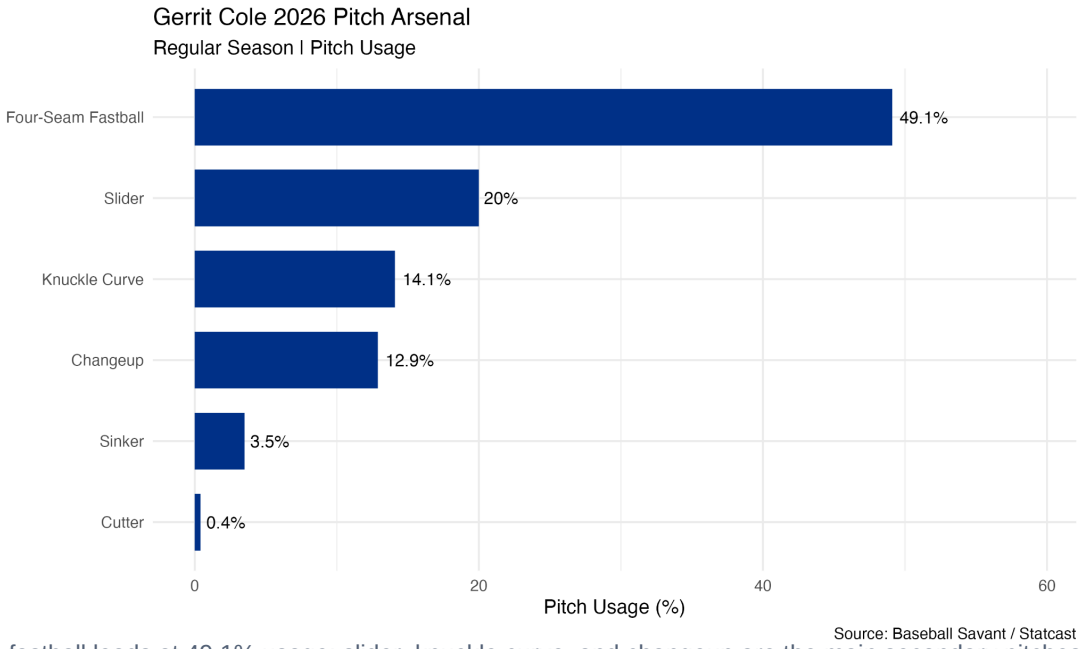
Analytical cautions

Some pitch and location groups have small samples. The 3-0 count and cutter results are especially sensitive to limited observations. Interpret the charts alongside sample sizes, pitch execution, handedness, and current scouting information.

Pitch arsenal and velocity

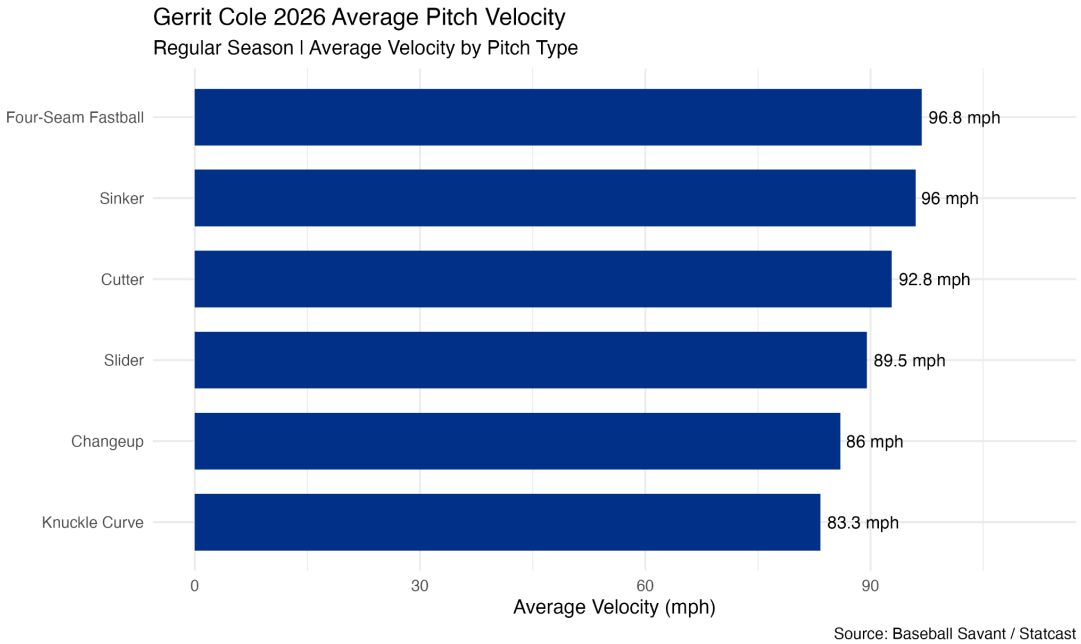
Usage and average velocity across six pitch types

Figure 1. Pitch arsenal



The four-seam fastball leads at 49.1% usage; slider, knuckle curve, and changeup are the main secondary pitches.

Figure 2. Average pitch velocity

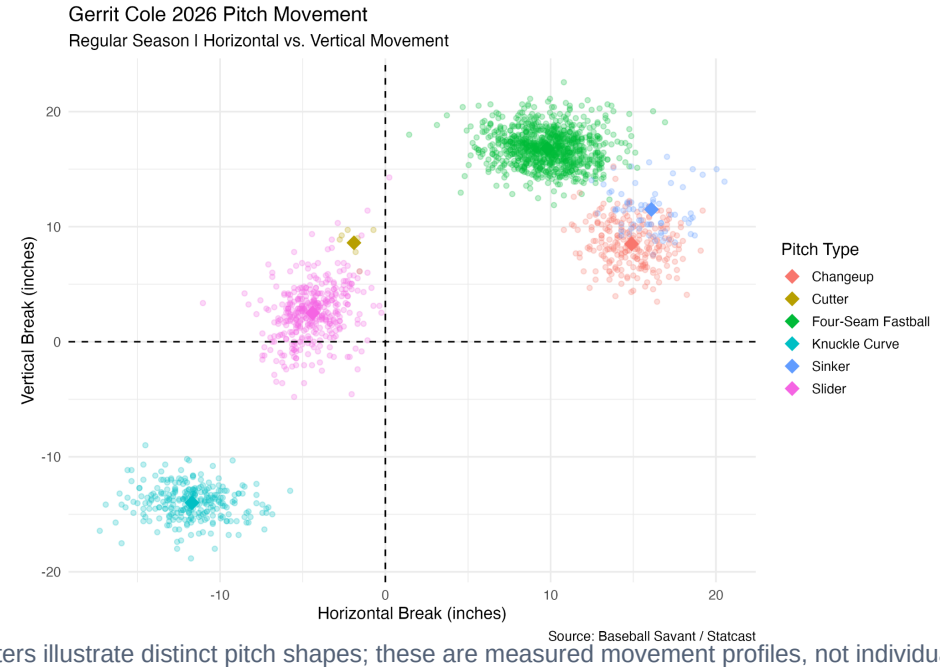


Cole averages 96.8 mph with his four-seam fastball, compared with 89.5 mph on the slider and 83.3 mph on the knuckle curve.

Movement and pitch location

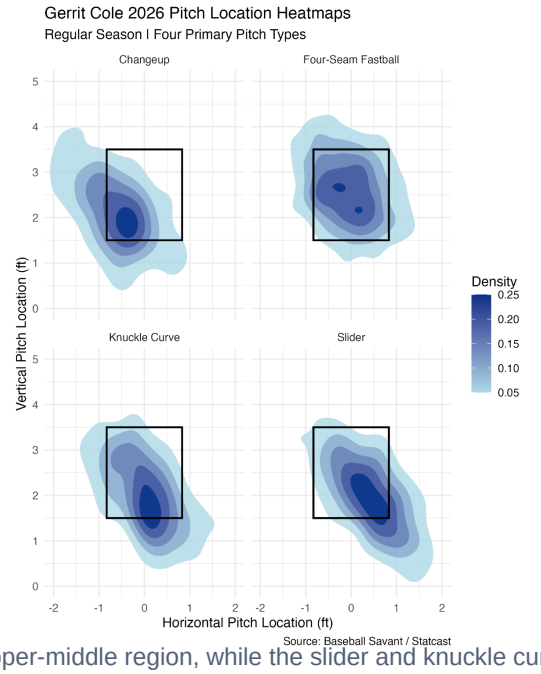
Pitch shapes and density of observed locations

Figure 3. Horizontal vs. vertical movement



The movement clusters illustrate distinct pitch shapes; these are measured movement profiles, not individual pitch grades.

Figure 4. Pitch location heatmaps

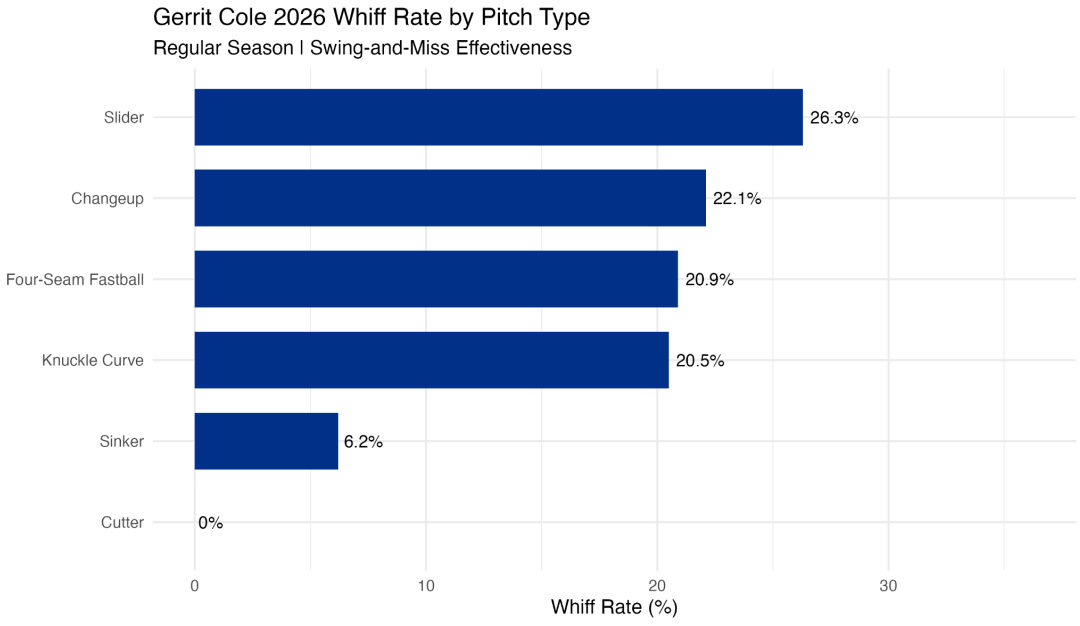


The four-seamer concentrates in the upper-middle region, while the slider and knuckle curve more often occupy lower areas.

Swing-and-miss effectiveness

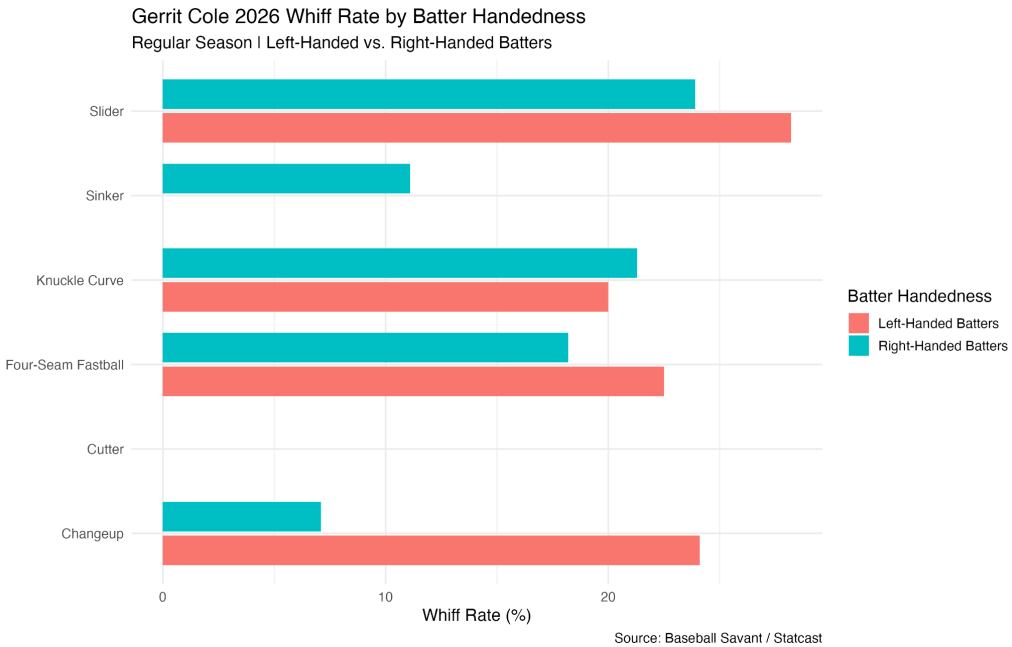
Overall results and handedness splits

Figure 5. Whiff rate by pitch type



The slider has the highest overall whiff rate (26.3%). The cutter has too few swings to draw a strong conclusion.

Figure 6. Whiff rate by batter handedness

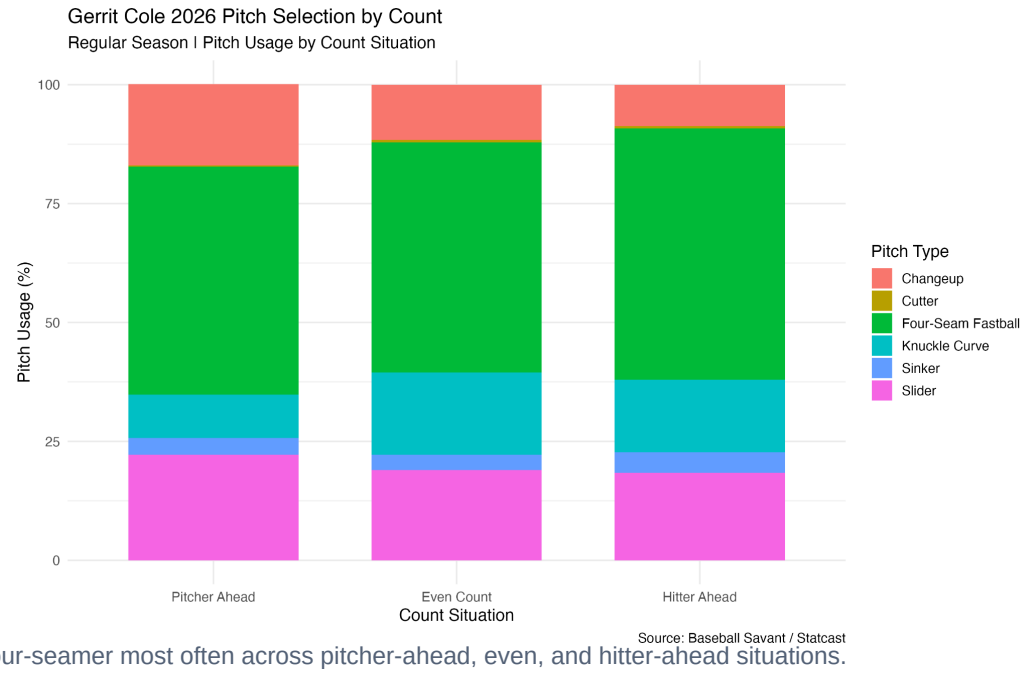


Differences by batter side may inform pitch sequencing, but each split should be evaluated with its underlying swing count.

Pitch strategy and location outcomes

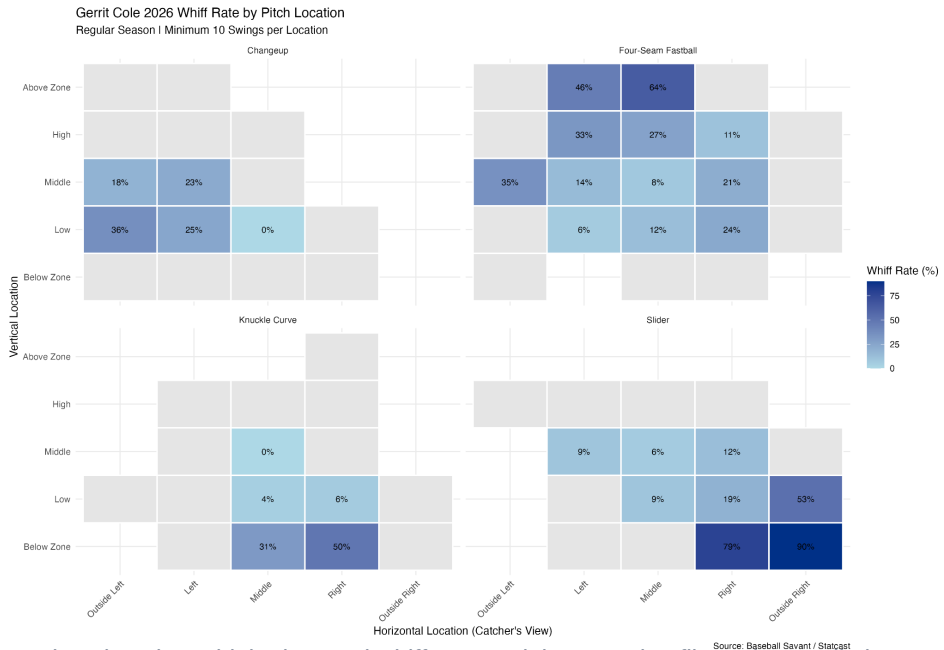
Count-based usage and whiff rate by location

Figure 7. Pitch selection by count situation



Cole uses the four-seamer most often across pitcher-ahead, even, and hitter-ahead situations.

Figure 8. Whiff rate by pitch location

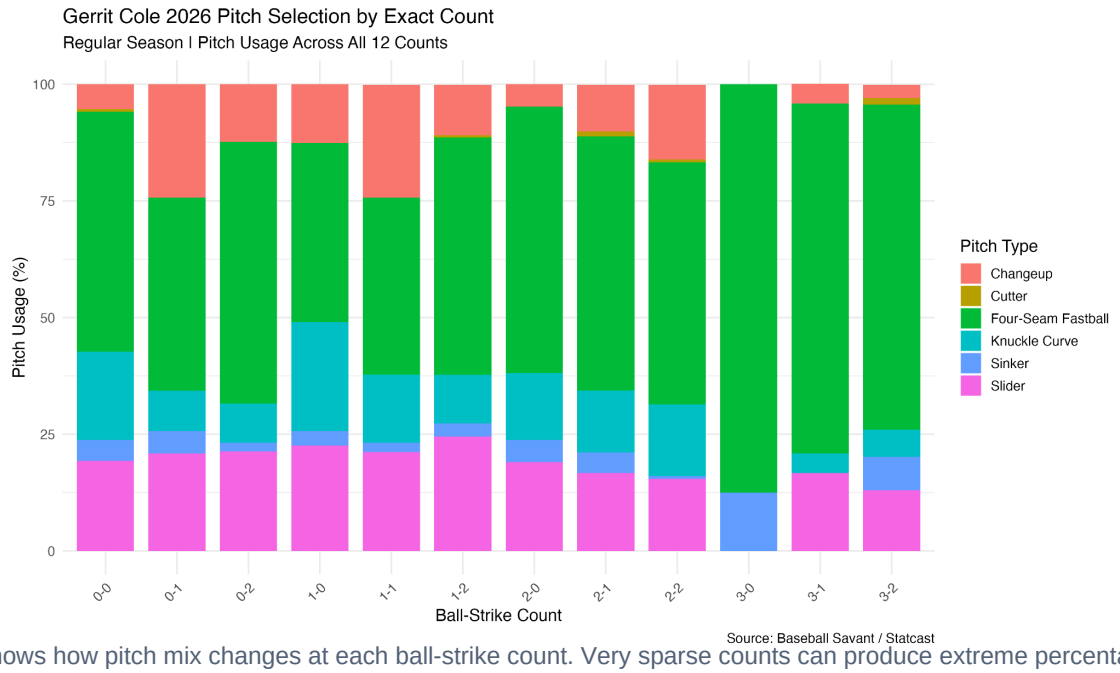


Some low or out-of-zone locations have high observed whiff rates; minimum-swing filters do not eliminate sampling uncertainty.

Exact counts and Boston hitter tendencies

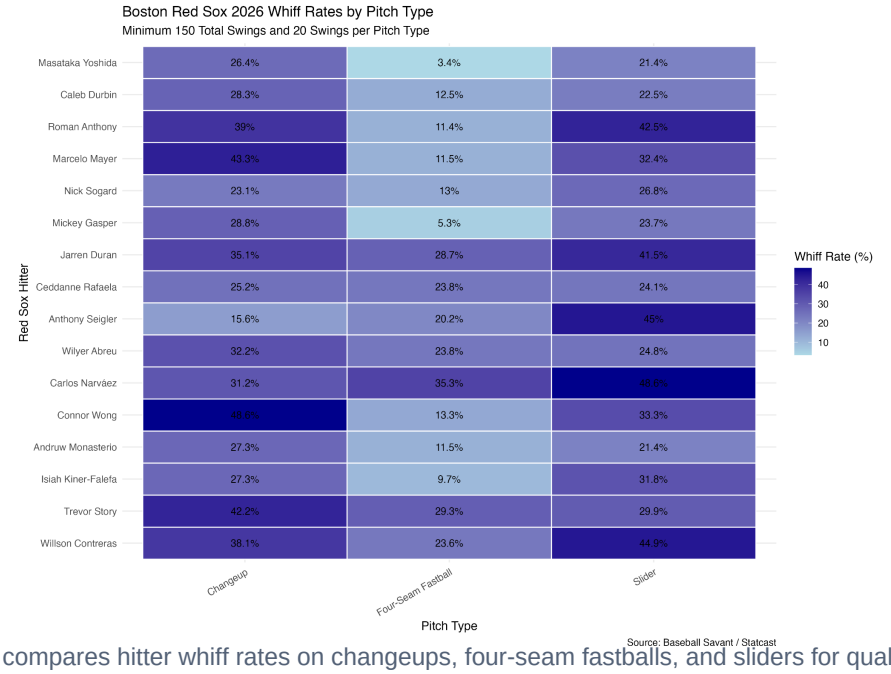
Pitch usage by exact count and hitter-specific whiff rates

Figure 9. Pitch selection by exact count



The chart shows how pitch mix changes at each ball-strike count. Very sparse counts can produce extreme percentages.

Figure 10. Boston hitters by pitch type

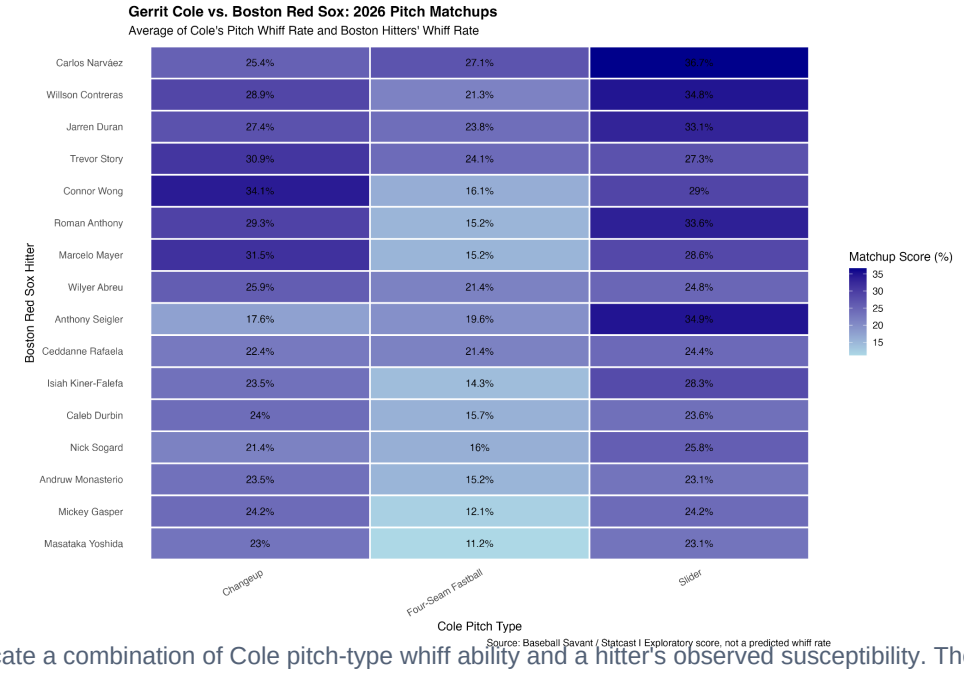


The Red Sox heatmap compares hitter whiff rates on changeups, four-seam fastballs, and sliders for qualifying swing samples.

Matchup prioritization

Exploratory Cole-versus-Boston comparison

Figure 11. Cole vs. Boston matchup heatmap



Higher scores indicate a combination of Cole pitch-type whiff ability and a hitter's observed susceptibility. They are not predicted rates.

Top five exploratory pitch matchups

Carlos Narvaez	Slider	**36.7%**
Anthony Seigler	Slider	**34.9%**
Willson Contreras	Slider	**34.8%**
Connor Wong	Changeup	**34.1%**
Roman Anthony	Slider	**33.6%**

Conclusions and recommendations

Prioritize slider-focused scouting for Narvaez, Seigler, Contreras, and Anthony; review changeup execution against Wong. Validate these comparisons with pitch location, batter swing decisions, current roster context, and larger samples before using them for in-game strategy.